

Retiring @40: Freedom, Fantasy, Or Financial Strategy?

AS BURNOUT, FINANCIAL INDEPENDENCE, AND CHANGING DEFINITIONS OF SUCCESS RESHAPE CAREERS, A GROWING NUMBER OF PROFESSIONALS ARE DISCOVERING THAT THE REAL GOAL ISN'T RETIREMENT BUT RECLAIMING CONTROL OVER TIME, WORK AND LIFE

BY MAMTA SHARMA

FORMER WIPRO AND Cognizant HR executive Amit Chilka went viral on the internet earlier this year for a decision that seemed to defy conventional wisdom. At 45, he stepped away from the corporate treadmill and relocated from Pune to Dehradun with a corpus of roughly ₹1 crore.

For many observers, this was not enough. But Chilka's version of financial independence was built on a different philosophy—he reduced his monthly expenses from ₹1.5 lakh to ₹50,000, left his investment corpus untouched, reinvested rental income, and continued earning through consulting, coaching, and leadership retreats.

The internet reacted with part admiration and part skepticism. Could someone retire in their 40s with what many considered a modest corpus? Was this financial independence or recklessness? More importantly, was the real story about money at all?

Across urban India, a growing number of professionals are planning exits from high-pressure corporate careers years before conventional retirement age. Some are moving to smaller cities. Others are shifting to

ILLUSTRATIONS BY RAHUL SHARMA/AI

